

Bartleby, the Scrivener

Herman Melville · 1853

First published: Putnam's Monthly, Nov–Dec 1853

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Piazza_Tales/Bartleby_the_Scrivener (revision 12985183), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about passive resistance?
- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about alienation in modern work?
- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about charity and responsibility?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Bartleby, the Scrivener	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*passive resistance* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Bartleby, the Scrivener

Focus: refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

Content note (death in prison): Sensitive content: Death in prison. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death in prison.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer learns Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office: 'Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity!'

Background: Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand.

Significance: Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes death in prison.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are cistern, benevolently, chimeras, obtruded, invocation. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern." In this sentence it means: a tank for storing water. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Bartleby, the Scrivener would have known. Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand. Why does this story matter? Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for point of view.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? I circle "surmises", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find point of view, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for point of view.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of point of view. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man. But indeed, nature herself seemed to have been his vintner, and at his birth charged him so thoroughly with an irritable, brandy-like disposition, that all subsequent potations were needless. When I consider how, amid the stillness of my chambers, Nippers would sometimes impatiently rise from his seat, and stooping over his table, spread his arms wide apart, seize the whole desk, and move it, and jerk it, with a grim, grinding motion on the floor, as if the table were a perverse voluntary agent, intent on thwarting and vexing him; I plainly perceive that for Nippers, brandy and water were altogether superfluous.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Point of view, Characterization, Symbolism: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to passive resistance? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cistern (noun)	a tank for storing water	*Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
benevolently (adverb)	in a kind, well-meaning way	*At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
chimeras (noun)	wild, impossible dreams or fantasies	*These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
obtruded (verb)	pushed forward unwelcome	*I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remarks obtruded upon me by my professional friends who visited the rooms.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
invocation (noun)	a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service	*Like a very ghost, agreeably to the laws of magical invocation, at the*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
unexampled (adjective)		*Instantly it occurred to me, that his unexampled diligence in*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

	never seen before; unequaled		
interment (noun)	the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave	*Imagination will readily supply the meager recital of poor Bartleby's interment.*	“interment”: From Old French enterrement "burial," from enterrer "to put in the earth" (Latin terra "earth"). (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/interment)
heighten (verb)	to increase	*Conceive a man by nature and misfortune prone to a pallid hopelessness, can any business seem more fitted to heighten it than that of continually handling these dead letters, and assorting them for the flames?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
surmises (noun)	guesses	*Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
penniless (adjective)	not having enough money to pay for necessities	*myself to be ignominiously repulsed by this lean, penniless wight?—my*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with passive resistance?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the narrator's profession? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A Wall Street lawyer

2. What is Bartleby's job? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Scrivener, or copyist
3. What is Bartleby's famous reply? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: I would prefer not to
4. What does the narrator finally do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Moves his offices away
5. Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The Dead Letter Office
6. Retell the three most important events of "Bartleby, the Scrivener" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer learns Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office:…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "Bartleby, the Scrivener"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "Bartleby, the Scrivener" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern." What does "cistern" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: cistern: a tank for storing water.
10. Reread: "At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct." What does "benevolently" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: benevolently: in a kind, well-meaning way.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "Bartleby, the Scrivener" suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. In the passage that begins "Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects,…", why might Melville have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "Bartleby, the Scrivener", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist,

Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison,…

6. As the opening story, what does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” set up that the rest of Bartleby, the Scrivener will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with passive resistance? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
10. Background: Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Bartleby, the Scrivener” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Bartleby, the Scrivener”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to alienation in modern work: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Melville need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “Bartleby, the Scrivener” treats refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Bartleby, the Scrivener see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve passive resistance? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Herman Melville about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz

1. What is the narrator's profession?
   A. A Wall Street lawyer
   B. A doctor
   C. A banker
   D. A judge
2. What is Bartleby's job?
   A. Accountant
   B. Clerk in a shop
   C. Scrivener, or copyist
   D. Messenger
3. What is Bartleby's famous reply?
   A. Not today
   B. I would prefer not to
   C. Leave me alone
   D. I cannot
4. What does the narrator finally do?
   A. Moves his offices away
   B. Fires everyone
   C. Calls the police at once
   D. Pays Bartleby to leave
5. Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor?
   A. A bank
   B. A ship
   C. The Dead Letter Office

D. A prison

6. In the line “Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.”, what does “cistern” most nearly mean?
   A. pushed forward unwelcome
   B. in a kind, well-meaning way
   C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies
   D. a tank for storing water
7. In the line “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.”, what does “benevolently” most nearly mean?
   A. a tank for storing water
   B. pushed forward unwelcome
   C. in a kind, well-meaning way
   D. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

Answer key: 1. A (A Wall Street lawyer); 2. C (Scrivener, or copyist); 3. B (I would prefer not to); 4. A (Moves his offices away); 5. C (The Dead Letter Office); 6. D (a tank for storing water); 7. C (in a kind, well-meaning way)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Bartleby, the Scrivener,” how does Melville show refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In Bartleby, the Scrivener, how does Melville develop the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Bartleby, the Scrivener

suggests about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Herman Melville uses point of view in Bartleby, the Scrivener to complicate the reader's understanding of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Bartleby, the Scrivener within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Bartleby, the Scrivener alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Bartleby, the Scrivener and its treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Bartleby, the Scrivener as evidence for a larger claim about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Bartleby, the Scrivener as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Bartleby, the Scrivener.

SAT-style questions

1. *These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “chimeras” most nearly mean?

   A. not having enough money to pay for necessities

   B. to increase

   C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

D. guesses

2. *Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man. But indeed, nature herself seemed to have been his vintner, and at his birth charged him so thoroughly with an irritable, brandy-like disposition, that all subsequent potations were needless. When I consider how, amid the stillness of my chambers, Nippers would sometimes impatiently rise from his seat, and stooping over his table, spread his arms wide apart, seize the whole desk, and move it, and jerk it, with a grim, grinding motion on the floor, as if the table were a perverse voluntary agent, intent on thwarting and vexing him; I plainly perceive that for Nippers, brandy and water were altogether superfluous.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Bartleby, the Scrivener"?

A. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

B. Science that poisons love

C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

D. A crime that backfires

SAT key: 1. C (wild, impossible dreams or fantasies); 2. A (Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve)

Whole-book test

Bartleby, the Scrivener: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What is the narrator's profession?
   A. A Wall Street lawyer
   B. A doctor
   C. A banker
   D. A judge
2. What is Bartleby's job?
   A. Accountant
   B. Clerk in a shop
   C. Scrivener, or copyist
   D. Messenger
3. What is Bartleby's famous reply?
   A. Not today
   B. I would prefer not to
   C. Leave me alone
   D. I cannot
4. What does the narrator finally do?
   A. Moves his offices away
   B. Fires everyone
   C. Calls the police at once
   D. Pays Bartleby to leave
5. Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor?
   A. A bank
   B. A ship
   C. The Dead Letter Office
   D. A prison
6. In the line “Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern.”, what does “cistern” most nearly mean?
   A. pushed forward unwelcome
   B. in a kind, well-meaning way
   C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies
   D. a tank for storing water

7. In the line “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.”, what does “benevolently” most nearly mean?
   A. a tank for storing water
   B. pushed forward unwelcome
   C. in a kind, well-meaning way
   D. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies
8. As used in the story (“Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine n”), what does “cistern” mean?
   A. a tank for storing water
   B. a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service
   C. to increase
   D. in a kind, well-meaning way
9. As used in the story (“At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his c”), what does “benevolently” mean?
   A. never seen before; unequaled
   B. in a kind, well-meaning way
   C. guesses
   D. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies
10. As used in the story (“These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities ”), what does “chimeras” mean?
    A. the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave
    B. not having enough money to pay for necessities
    C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies
    D. pushed forward unwelcome
11. As used in the story (“I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remark”), what does “obtruded” mean?
    A. to increase
    B. a tank for storing water
    C. a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service
    D. pushed forward unwelcome
12. As used in the story (“Like a very ghost, agreeably to the laws of magical invocation, at the”), what does “invocation” mean?
    A. a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service
    B. guesses
    C. in a kind, well-meaning way
    D. never seen before; unequaled

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how passive resistance develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how alienation in modern work develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how charity and responsibility develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (passive resistance, alienation in modern work, charity and responsibility) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (A Wall Street lawyer); 2. C (Scrivener, or copyist); 3. B (I would prefer not to); 4. A (Moves his offices away); 5. C (The Dead Letter Office); 6. D (a tank for storing water); 7. C (in a kind, well-meaning way); 8. A (a tank for storing water); 9. B (in a kind, well-meaning way); 10. C (wild, impossible dreams or fantasies); 11. D (pushed forward unwelcome); 12. A (a prayer asking God's help as part of a religious service)

Essay assignments

Essay: Passive resistance

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about passive resistance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops passive resistance across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of passive resistance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of passive resistance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of passive resistance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Alienation in modern work

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about alienation in modern work. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops alienation in modern work across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of alienation in modern work. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of alienation in modern work, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of alienation in modern work in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Charity and responsibility

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about charity and responsibility. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops charity and responsibility across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of charity and responsibility. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of charity and responsibility, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of charity and responsibility in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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